

Chapter 4

DHARMIC INSIGHTS OF A BUTCHER

Are you ready to unlock the secrets of the ages?

The greatest teachers await us in the most unexpected places. You shouldn't be surprised when a Butcher imparts invaluable insights on Dharma.



Chapter 4

DHARMIC INSIGHTS OF A BUTCHER

It is fair to say that the Bhagavadgītā is the crest jewel of Mahābhārata. Bhagavadgītā is the pendant of the long string of pearls, which we call the Mahābhārata. But there are two other Gītās - Uddhava Gīta and Vyādha Gīta. Bhagavadgītā was delivered by Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa to Arjuna, and Uddhava Gīta by Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa to Uddhava, his long-standing friend and disciple. The Vyādha Gīta is a highly philosophical account explicating Advaita philosophy. Vyādha stands for 'butcher', therefore, Vyādha Gīta is the Gīta delivered by a butcher. A butcher's job, you may know, is cutting and selling meat. This Vyādha Gīta comprises profound philosophical nuances. There exists a story behind it that holds the essence of karma yoga, the definition of work and worship.

A young Brahmin boy decides to renounce the world, go to a forest, leaving his old parents, and do tapas (austerities) to attain Bhagavān (God) and truth. This may resonate with

the story of Gautama Buddhā, but this happens before the time of Buddhā. In fact, this happens at the time when the Pāṇḍavas are in the forest. His parents requested their son to stay back and look after them as they were getting old and had no one else to take care of them.

But the adamant son left them and went to the forest one fine day. He started doing tapas in that forest. For many years he did meditation, tapas, etc. Traditionally, most people think that spirituality is doing things like leaving everything, going to a forest, and doing tapas there and that was exactly what he did. After several years, his concentration improved and he gained unique powers. One day, a crane came and sat on top of the tree under which he was meditating. Crane does not discriminate between who is sitting under the tree. The crane is incapable of distinguishing a yogi from an ordinary person. The bird then happened to evacuate, and it fell on the Yogi's head. He snapped out of his meditation. The man looked up at the crane with his eyes burning with fury. And the bird was burned to ashes. The man was amused at his own power and grew proud of himself.

He usually went to seek bhikṣā from the nearby village. He beseeched for food by chanting 'bhavati bhikṣam dehī'. He went to one house where a lady was preparing food. She was busy taking care of her husband who had just come home from work. So she told the young Brahmachāri to wait. This infuriated him and he yelled at her for making a great man like himself wait till her chores were done.)

But the lady replied with a smile, "My Son, Do you think I'm a crane so that you can burn me up? I am not a Crane. Please take this food." The Brahmachāri was shocked that this lady knew about the incident with the crane.



Seeing the shock on his face, the lady calmly added, "My Son, I prioritised my duty, which is to feed my tired husband. You don't seem to know anything about yoga or spirituality yet. You have a wrong assumption about it. I don't have time to teach you. So I suggest you go to the next village and seek the guidance of a person called Dharmavyādha. He will teach you Vedic yoga and the real essence of spirituality.

This hurt his ego, especially because a lady who hasn't read the Vedas, read his mind and suggested him to seek the

guidance of another man. Humbled, the young man went to the next village. He asked a few people about Dharmavyādha. They looked at him very quizzically and they showed him the way. Finally, he reached Dharmavyādha's place and was astounded to see a butcher.

The place looked just like an ordinary slaughterhouse with an overpowering stench of blood and meat hanging in front of the shop. While the Brahmacāri was studying the place, the butcher came out and said, "Son! Did the lady send you here? Come in". This further shook the Brahmacāri and he thought, "How did the butcher know about the lady?" The butcher with a smile told him, "Come in, I will teach you". By now, his ego was completely smashed. Dharmavyādha welcomed the Brahmacāri to his place. He then saw Dharmavyādha busy with attending to his parents. All this while, the young man was waiting and watching what Dharmavyādha was doing.

Mystified by all these unexpected experiences, the ascetic asked him why, in spite of his great wisdom, he was doing this gruesome work of a butcher. The butcher replied, "My son, you thought running into a forest and acquiring powers through meditation can make you an accomplished man! Well, you are wrong. You are sinned by killing the crane. You killed the crane because you were blind with anger and had no control over your mind or actions. This is not spirituality."

The man's ego was completely wiped out hearing this.

Dharmavyādha continued, "My son, no duty is ugly, no duty is impure. My birth placed me in these circumstances and environments. I learned this trade in my boyhood; I am unattached, and I try to do my duty well. I do all I can to make my father and mother happy."

Vyādha Gīta starts with the butcher teaching the Brahmacāri about how to worship one's work no matter what it is. He taught him that disinterest in work will reflect in the performance of duties.

This story actually comes in the Vana Parva, when the Pāṇḍavas are in the forest.

In Mahābhārata, Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa says that by considering work as worship, one can attain supremacy. People like King Janaka have attained supremacy through karma yoga - by considering their actions as worship. The butcher and the lady showed the Brahmacāri their devotion to their duties. The woman whole-heartedly served her husband and the butcher served his old parents with utmost reverence, without expecting any reward. They considered it as their duty and simply did it as an offering to the absolute. This has made them attain their goal. So the Butcher told the Brahmacāri, "You need to go back to your home, and take care of your parents first".

Swāmi Vivekānanda says the Vyādha Gīta contains the heights of the Advaita philosophy which propagates the idea of renunciation. When the all pervading self, the true reality is constantly within us, renunciation is not all about going

away from the house, taking shelter in a forest, and becoming an ascetic. One can be a householder yet engage in spiritual endeavour. Ramaṇa Maharṣi says that one can change from a householder to an ascetic. But the point is to find out who the "I" is and to go beyond it.

A lady once requested Ammā to give her "enlightenment" or realisation. Ammā smiled at her and said, "Continue doing whatever you are doing, you will reach there one day".

She told her that the Yajña conducted by King Dakṣa turned into a battleground due to his audacity, whereas, with his dedication and faith in Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa, Arjuna turned the Kurukṣetra battleground into a place of worship.

The Brahmin in the story was undergoing the so-called spiritual austerities and was doing so with the ego that ended up pushing him into the pit of ignorance. Spirituality is not about running away from one's actions, or avoiding the basic duties and bindings of human existence. Just by serving their family with devotion, sense of duty, and complete detachment to any reward, the lady and the butcher become good examples of Karma Yoga.